The Communication and Change Plan

Change management is not a communication plan. A communication plan is change management.

From AI Will Scale Good Leadership and Bad Leadership: The CHRO's Method for Redesigning Work Before AI Scales What's Broken, by Liz Corey | Toolbox No. 13

Three pages, one tool. Page 1 locks the messages and the dates before any announcement. Page 2 sequences the work that makes those messages credible. Page 3 is the page a frontline leader fills in for their own team, because the leaders in the middle are the most common point of failure and of success. An empty cell on any page is a decision not yet made.

Inputs this tool expects. The audience groups come from the Work Assignment Matrix (Chapter 6, Toolbox No. 6). The messenger for each decision comes from the Decision Rights Matrix (Chapter 7, Toolbox No. 7). The feedback measures are the four items in the AI-Era Listening Set (Chapter 12, Toolbox No. 12). The routine that carries the message is the GROWTH Conversation Guide (Chapter 11, Toolbox No. 11). The resistance points come from the Ambiguity Inventory on the No-Surprises Protocol (this toolbox). If you have not built one of those yet, this page will tell you which one, because its cells will be the empty ones. These tools work together. They are not separate forms to complete and file.

Page 1: The AI Communication Plan

Lock the words and the dates before anyone hears anything.

1 Purpose and success

The business reason, with a number	*Not "AI is the future." The problem or the opportunity, and the figure that proves it.*
What people must understand or do, and by when	*Specific behaviors, dated.*

2 Audiences and their primary concern

Grouped by what changes for them. The Work Assignment Matrix drew the first four.

Audience	What changes for them (one sentence)	Their primary concern
Tasks moving to Automate or Agent		
Tasks gaining Assist		
Leaders who now own an agent		
People whose work does not change		

3 Core messages

Write the actual language. If you cannot write the sentence, the decision is not firm enough to announce.

Why we are doing this	
What changes and what stays the same, for this group	
Roles, capacity, and jobs: decided, and still open	*Say what is decided. Say what is not, and when it will be. Say what the company will do with the capacity AI frees. Silence on that question is heard as "cuts."*
What is allowed and not allowed	*Approved tools. Data that never enters them. Where human review stays required.*
Where to get help and how to raise a question	

4 Message calendar

The order is fixed. Leaders are briefed before any employee hears. The most affected employees hear before any broad announcement. Routines carry it after.

Message	Owner	Date	Channel
Strategic message from the sponsor			
Leader briefing and talking points (before any team hears)			
Team-level role conversations (most affected first, face to face)			
Operational and training detail			
Post-launch reinforcement (cadence, not a date)			

5 Feedback loop and leadership modeling

How input is collected, reviewed, and answered	*Channel, reviewer, response date. A channel nobody answers is silence that looks like process.*
What leaders will visibly do, and by when, to match the words	*Modeling matters more than endorsement emails.*

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Page 2: The AI Change Plan

Sequence the work that makes the dated messages credible. Each row has a test. Answer it honestly or leave it blank; a blank is more useful than a guess.

Element	The test	Your answer	Date
Change summary	Business reason, scope, success definition, and what the freed capacity is for. Is there a number next to the reason, and a plan next to the capacity?		
Sponsor and roles	Named executive sponsor, change lead, leader responsibilities, champions. What did the sponsor do with the tool this week, and which obstacle did they remove?		
Impact assessment deadline	Date by which group-level impacts and concerns are documented. Must precede the final messages, not follow them.		
Leader enablement calendar	Dates for briefing packs, FAQs, and coaching support before team conversations. Were leaders asked what worries them before they were asked to brief anyone?		
Enablement schedule	Training windows, champion early access, and the refresh cadence tied to tool releases. The tools keep changing. Does the plan loop?		
Governance basics	Approved tools, data rules, human review points, each with an effective date. Do senior people follow the same rules? If not, the organization has learned the real policy.		
Reinforcement and measures	Baseline the four AI-Era Listening Set items before the first message. Pulse them again two weeks after it, then at 30, 60, 90 days and quarterly, reported beside usage, quality, and outcomes.		
Risks and adjustments	The top resistance points from the Ambiguity Inventory, and the date each one gets a response or a plan change.		

The stage check

People move through change in stages. William Bridges called them the ending, the neutral zone, and the new beginning. The stage an audience is in decides what they can hear. A plan that forgets that is a schedule, not a plan.

Audience	Stage right now	What they can hear	What clarity or support they need now
Tasks moving to Automate or Agent	Ending / Neutral zone / New beginning		
Tasks gaining Assist	Ending / Neutral zone / New beginning		
Leaders who now own an agent	Ending / Neutral zone / New beginning		
People whose work does not change	Ending / Neutral zone / New beginning		

The stage decides the order and the support, never whether people get the information. Every entry in the last column needs an owner and a date in the message calendar on page 1.

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Page 3: The Leader's Translation

What each leader must understand, communicate, and demonstrate. Twenty minutes, in your own words, before you talk to anyone. Your CHRO will ask for this page back.

Why this page exists. The strategic message came from the sponsor. Your team will not act on it until they hear what it means for their work, from you. That translation is a leadership behavior, not a forwarding task. If you cannot fill a cell, that is information: take it back up the line before you take it to your team.

The business reason, in my words	*One or two sentences a person on my team would recognize as true.*
What changes for us	*Task by task, from the Work Assignment Matrix (Toolbox No. 6). Which tasks move, to where, and when, and what we will do with the time that frees.*
What does not change for us	*Say it plainly. Vague reassurance creates more anxiety than silence.*
What is decided about roles, capacity, and jobs	
What is still open, and when I will know	
The three-part message, in my words	*Here is what we know. Here is what we do not know yet. Here is when you will hear more.*
What is allowed and not allowed on my team	*Approved tools. Data that never goes in. Where I still review.*
Questions I expect, and my answers	*Write at least five. The one you are avoiding is the one that will be asked first.*
What I will visibly do differently	*The behavior my team will see that matches the words.*
How my team raises a concern, and how fast I respond	
First conversation: date and setting	*Most affected people first, face to face.*
Next conversation: date	*A plan with one conversation on it is an announcement.*

For the CHRO. Hand this page to every leader with a redesign on their team. Collect it back before their first team conversation. The pages that come back complete tell you who can build a plan. The pages that come back blank tell you where the improvising will happen, and that is where you coach first. Review the set at the enablement council each month.

Five leadership choices, none of them a technology problem

A sponsor who uses the tools. Not an endorsement email. A named executive who runs the agent and removes the obstacle the team named last week.

Leaders in the middle with accurate talking points. Frame, role-level translation, room to raise their own concerns first, support to coach. Leave them to improvise and you scale mixed leadership on purpose.

The people who do the work in the room. They mapped their own tasks in Chapter 5. Tell them what happened to their map; do not sell them the redesign.

Repetition through routines. Sponsor frames, leaders translate, the meetings that already exist reinforce. GROWTH is the routine. Communication is a repeated behavior, not an announcement.

Feedback treated as data. Training, champions, office hours, and a feedback path with visible responses. Do leaders treat what comes back as data or as noise?

AI does not invent leadership quality. It amplifies whatever exists. A communication and change plan is one of the clearest places that amplification happens. Build it well and AI scales it. Leave it vague and AI scales that instead.

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